

Editorial

It's Not Windows Enough

THE APPLE-MICROSOFT RIVALRY broke into a new battleground last month with the launch of Apple's Safari 3.0 browser—in public beta—for both Windows and Mac OS X. A million downloads of the browser for Windows were clocked right in the first week after the launch. Speculation is rife in regards to this totally unexpected move by Apple.

One school of thought says the motive for this is to invite more developers to code applications for the iPhone, which runs on Mac OS X. Apple has made an attempt to pitch Web-based applications—which, naturally, imply Safari—as the iPhone developer platform. The other possible reason for Apple having released Safari for Windows could be that Apple simply wants to increase its browser market share, which, as you know, lags way behind IE or even Firefox. And with Microsoft still battling the lawsuit on its bundling of IE with its operating systems, there might still be a chance for Apple of taking a lead in this new browser war—if Microsoft loses the case.

History, though, tells us a different tale. It is common knowledge that Apple has never quite been successful at building applications for the Windows platform. The QuickTime media player failed miserably; iTunes is far from having become the default media file management software for PC users. So what are the chances of Safari picking up steam?

The initial, scathing reviews are hardly encouraging. Barely a few hours after the announcement of Safari for Windows, security experts found not less than 18 security holes in the browser. Technology experts, prominent tech bloggers, and message boards have ridiculed Safari for a buggy beta; the user interface enthusiasts are disappointed with the look and feel. The worst of all, it's slow. The problem could quite simply be that Safari for Windows wasn't built for the regular Windows user. It's not Windows enough: for example, Safari uses Mac OS X font anti-aliasing instead of Windows' inbuilt ClearType, and fonts look blurry and bold. Menus are hard to read. Safari uses its own set of key combinations for things like flipping through tabs—which is not a universal standard, let alone a habit for IE users.



Deepak Ajwani Executive Editor

“Apple has never quite been successful at building applications for the Windows platform”

So when Apple tries to force down a Windows user's throat its own idea of a “superior” user interface, it is not taken to with kindness.

Windows users might have been forced to use iTunes if they wanted to play their iPods, but it's still an irritant to those used to the convenience of drag-and-drop offered by Windows media player. Similarly, for a browser, Apple will need to do things the Windows way and follow the standards expected by the Windows user. It might get away with it's our-way-or-the-highway attitude for its own products—the Mac, the iPod, or even the iPhone, but to successfully lure Windows users, the approach they need to take will be one of humility.

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'D. Ajwani'.

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